



MIGRAINE

Understanding the Causes, Symptoms
and Management

A Simple, Informative Guide for Patients and Families

What Is a Migraine?

A migraine is not just “a bad headache.” It is a common neurological condition that causes recurring attacks of moderate to severe head pain, often accompanied by other symptoms such as nausea, sensitivity to light and sound, and visual disturbances. Migraine attacks can last anywhere from a few hours to a few days and can significantly disrupt daily life, work, and relationships.

Migraine affects people of all ages but is most common in adults between 20 and 50 years old, and it occurs roughly three times more often in women than in men. It is considered one of the leading causes of disability worldwide.

Did You Know?

Migraine is a genuine medical condition with a strong genetic component — if one parent has migraine, a child has roughly a 40% chance of developing it too.

The Four Phases of a Migraine Attack

Not everyone experiences all four phases, and they don't always occur in the same order. Recognising them can help you understand and manage an attack better.

1. Prodrome	Hours to a day before the headache. Subtle signs such as mood changes, food cravings, neck stiffness, yawning, or fatigue.
2. Aura	Occurs in about 1 in 3 people. Temporary visual disturbances (flashing lights, zigzag lines, blind spots), tingling, or difficulty speaking, usually lasting 20–60 minutes.
3. Headache (Attack)	Throbbing or pulsing pain, often on one side of the head, worsened by movement. May include nausea, vomiting, and sensitivity to light, sound, or smell.
4. Postdrome	The “migraine hangover.” Feeling drained, confused, or mildly unwell for up to a day after the headache eases.

Common Symptoms

- Throbbing or pulsating pain, usually on one side of the head
- Nausea and/or vomiting
- Increased sensitivity to light (photophobia) and sound (phonophobia)
- Blurred vision or visual auras (flashing lights, zigzag patterns)
- Dizziness or lightheadedness
- Tingling or numbness in the face, hands, or arms

- Difficulty concentrating (“brain fog”)

Common Triggers

Migraine triggers vary widely from person to person. Keeping a simple diary of attacks can help you identify your own personal patterns.

Lifestyle	Stress, poor sleep or oversleeping, skipping meals, dehydration, intense exercise
Diet	Caffeine (too much or withdrawal), alcohol (especially red wine), aged cheese, processed meats, artificial sweeteners
Environment	Bright or flickering lights, loud noise, strong smells, weather or barometric pressure changes
Hormonal	Menstrual cycle changes, pregnancy, hormonal contraceptives, menopause
Other	Certain medications, travel and jet lag, screen overuse

Managing and Reducing Migraine Attacks

During an attack:

- Rest in a quiet, dark room as soon as symptoms begin
- Apply a cold or warm compress to the head or neck
- Stay hydrated and take medication early, as advised by your doctor
- Practise slow, deep breathing to help manage pain and stress

Long-term prevention:

- Keep a consistent sleep schedule
- Eat regular, balanced meals and stay hydrated
- Manage stress through relaxation techniques, yoga, or light exercise
- Track attacks in a migraine diary to identify personal triggers
- Limit caffeine and alcohol intake
- Follow your doctor's guidance on preventive medication if attacks are frequent

When to See a Doctor

Seek prompt medical attention for a headache that is sudden and severe ("worst headache of your life"), follows a head injury, comes with fever, stiff neck, confusion, seizures, double vision, weakness, or numbness — or if your usual headache pattern changes significantly.

Myths vs. Facts

Myth	Fact
Migraine is just a bad headache.	Migraine is a distinct neurological disorder with many symptoms beyond pain.
Only adults get migraines.	Children and teenagers can experience migraines too.
Painkillers alone can cure migraine.	Overusing painkillers can cause “medication-overuse headaches”; a broader management plan works best.
Migraine is “all in your head” psychologically.	It has measurable neurological and vascular changes in the brain.

Final Word

Migraine is manageable with the right knowledge, lifestyle adjustments, and medical support. If your headaches are frequent, severe, or disrupting your daily life, consult a doctor or neurologist for a proper diagnosis and a personalised treatment plan. You do not have to manage it alone.

This guide is for general educational purposes only and does not replace professional medical advice, diagnosis, or treatment. Always consult a qualified healthcare provider regarding any medical condition.